

Evidently, if parents have not to pay school fees for their children and if their children can be made 'earning units' of the family at the end of their seven years of Wardha education, there may not be any perceptible opposition to the seven years of compulsory education, provided measures are taken to enlighten the public on the benefits of this system of education to the child as well as to the parent.

II. Emphasis on Indian Languages

(a) *The Mother-Tongue.* The next important feature of the Wardha Scheme is the emphasis laid on the mother-tongue in the scheme of teaching and studies. The resolution on this feature says that the medium of instruction must be the mother-tongue. Much more importance is deservedly given to the mother-tongue in the syllabus by the committee. It is not only to become the medium of instruction, but it is to occupy the first place among languages—a place hitherto occupied by English. Today English is the first language, the mother-tongue or the language of the district¹ is the second language, and anything else may come in as the third and the fourth. But under the Wardha system, the mother-tongue will take the place of English as the first language and as medium of instruction, and Hindustani will be given the place of second language, English being thus banned from the Wardha school. The position may be summed up in the words of Sri Mashruwala:

¹ In the case of pupils whose mother-tongue is one which has no alphabet or literature, like Konkani and Tulu, the language of the district will take the place of the mother-tongue in the scheme of education.

. . . A good knowledge of the mother-tongue, a fair acquaintance with its literature, a working knowledge of the national language of India . . .

That the medium of instruction should be the mother-tongue, and not English, is almost beyond controversy. So too the position of the mother-tongue as the first language of study is admitted on all hands. But there is some reasonable difference of opinion as to the place that should be assigned to English in the Wardha school. As a language of culture and of international communication some place may have to be given to English even in a system of national education; but that is a matter which may be left to the Provincial Governments who will adapt the Wardha Scheme to the circumstances of their provinces. We shall discuss this point in the chapter on 'Criticisms'.

Emphasizing this feature of the scheme, the committee says in the first *Report*:

The proper teaching of the mother-tongue is the foundation of all education. Without the capacity to speak effectively and to read and write correctly and lucidly, no one can develop precision of thought or clarity of ideas. Moreover, it is a means of introducing the child to the rich heritage of his people's ideas, emotions and aspirations, and can therefore be made a valuable means of social education, whilst also instilling right ethical and moral values. Also, it is a natural outlet for the expression of the child's aesthetic sense and appreciation, and if the proper approach is adopted, the study of literature becomes a source of joy and creative appreciation.

And in the syllabus on mother-tongue the committee has done well in having stressed 'both the creative and the utilitarian values of language and literature', and the teacher is expected 'to organize his oral work as well as his reading material round the actual but

growing life and interests of his children'. Thus the language syllabus too is child-centred.

(b) *Hindustani*. By the side of the mother-tongue the Wardha Scheme has assigned to Hindustani a reasonable and justifiable position among the subjects of study as a *compulsory second language*. Justifying this position, the committee says in the first *Report*:

The object of including Hindustani as a compulsory subject in the school curriculum is to ensure that all the children educated in these national schools may have a reasonable acquaintance with a common lingua franca. As adult citizens they should be able to co-operate with their fellow-countrymen belonging to any part of the country. In teaching the language the teacher should in various ways quicken in the students the realization that this language is the most important product of the cultural contact of the Hindus and Muslims in India. It is the repository—in its more advanced forms—of their best thoughts and aspirations. They should learn to take pride in its richness and vitality and should feel the desire to serve it devotedly.

It is worth noting that in the Hindustani-speaking areas this language will naturally be the mother-tongue, but in other areas it is proposed to impart only a working knowledge of this language, just enough to serve the purpose for which it is introduced as a second language. This fact is corroborated by the provision made in the syllabus of Grade VII which is the highest class in the Wardha school. What this syllabus attempts is to enable the student:

1. To be able to make a short speech and to engage in conversation;
2. To write simple and business letters.
3. To read simple books, periodicals and newspapers.

One more fact worth emphasizing is that, in non-Hindustani-speaking areas, where the provincial or district language will be the mother-tongue and, therefore, the first language of study and also the medium of instruction, 'the study of Hindustani will be compulsory during the fifth and sixth years of school life', but the children will have the choice of learning either one or other of the scripts (Arabic or Nagari), teachers having to know both scripts.

If such is the restricted scope of studying Hindustani in non-Hindustani-speaking areas, one need not apprehend any rivalry between Hindustani and the mother-tongue, and therefore Hindustani will never endanger, much less kill, languages like Tamil, Telugu, Kannada or Malayalam, in spite of the contrary contention of the lovers of these languages.

✓ III. Matriculation Standard

Though according to Mahatmaji, his scheme is one of 'primary' education, it includes what we now understand by elementary and secondary education. On this point too much ignorance is displayed by some; they think the Wardha schoolboy will attain only the level of a boy who reads up to Standard VIII of a Higher Elementary school in the Madras Province, and simply laugh at the idea of his attaining the matriculation standard in Grade VII of a Wardha school. Let us hear Mahatmaji who has made it clear that the Wardha school aims at the matriculation standard, though with a curriculum of studies different from our present Matriculation or Secondary School Leaving Certificate Examination.

1. In his very first article on his plan of education,

in *Harijan* of July 31, 1937, he hinted at his conception of 'primary' education:

I attach the greatest importance to primary education which, according to my conception, should be equal to the *present matriculation less English*.

2. In a later article he formulated his two propositions, already referred to, in which he clarified and amplified his plan:

Primary education, extending over a period of seven years or longer, and covering *all the subjects up to the matriculation standard, except English, plus a vocation . . .* should take the place of what passes today under the name of primary, middle and high school education. (*Harijan*, October 2, 1937.)

3. He made himself still more clear when he explained the point to Sri Ravishanker Shukla:

I should combine into one what you call now primary education and secondary or high school education. It is my conviction that our children get nothing more in the high schools than a half-baked knowledge of English, besides a superficial knowledge of mathematics and history and geography, some of which they had learnt in their own language in the primary classes. If you cut out English from the curriculum altogether, without cutting out the subjects you teach, you can make the children go through the whole course in seven years, instead of eleven, besides giving them manual work whereby they can make a fair return to the State.

In his inaugural address at the Conference, he not only explained his plan of combining secondary education with primary education, but also pointed out the reasons why he urges this revolutionary reform in the existing system of education. He said:

I have included secondary in primary education because primary education is the only education so-called that is available to a very small fraction of the people in our villages—many of which I have seen during my peregrinations since 1915. I have seen, perhaps more than anybody else, the conditions of Indian villages. . . . I know fully well the type of education that is given in Indian villages. And now that I have settled down in Segaon I can study the whole problem of national education from closer quarters. I am convinced that if we wish to ameliorate rural conditions we must combine secondary with primary education.

As in the case of some of the other features of the Wardha Scheme, so too on the question of the matriculation standard, people have shown ignorance which arises out of imperfect knowledge. Indeed, for people who are accustomed to a system of eleven years education, comprising the elementary and secondary stages—five years of elementary and six years of secondary—it is really difficult to realize how it is possible to finish off both the stages in a period of seven years. If, however, they will examine the syllabus carefully, they will be convinced of the feasibility of combining both the elementary and secondary stages of education in seven years. In fact, it will be found that, barring the knowledge of English in the present matriculation course, a boy who emerges from a Wardha school will have a standard of knowledge and formation which is decidedly higher than that of a modern matriculate or Secondary School Leaving Certificate holder. (See the chapter on 'The Wardha Syllabus'.)

IV. Different Steps in Education

From the point of view of the different steps in the process of education, the Wardha Scheme is different